end the absurd position which the British government had allowed itself to get into by its patronage of the Cossack Division.[73]

Thus, by the end of 1920, the British government faced a catalogue of humiliations in Persia. The inability of Curzon to have his agreement ratified by the Persian Parliament was just one indicator of the loss of status and prestige which Britain now experienced in that country. The forced retreat of the British army from Enzeli in the face of a Red Army incursion was only made worse by the comparative successes of Staroselskii and his Cossack Division. It is, therefore, unsurprising that in 1920 the Persian government came to the conclusion that it could no longer rely on Britain for financial help and military protection. In December 1920 Edmund Overy in the Foreign Office accused the Persian government of touting to America those concessions which had previously been in Russia's possession. Now that the Persian government had 'practically exhausted the milch cow of the British Government', it was evidently looking to America for financial aid; an act which displeased the British Foreign Office but one which it could do little about.[74] It could also do little to prevent Persia from seeking an alliance with the Soviet government either. In July, Norman reported that Mushir ed-Dowleh was talking of despatching a Persian mission to Moscow in order to discuss the recent events.[75] From the Persian point of view, such a move was essential. The actions of May had marked the ascendancy of the Soviet government on the international stage, and the Persian government could no longer afford to pursue its hitherto policy of ignoring the Bolshevik regime. As Norman explained, the 'weakness of Persia's geographical and military position obliges them to make such an agreement [with the Bolsheviks], more especially since they have more than once [been] told that Great Britain cannot defend her against serious invasion'.[76] For the British government, the attempt – which had characterised its foreign policy in 1918–1919 – to take advantage of Russia's weakness to bring Persia under its sole influence appeared to have failed.

Bolshevist Bogeys